



LESSON 7.1 : BUILDING CHORD TRIADS AND INVERSIONS

Introduction: The Foundation of Harmony

Chord triads are the foundation of harmony and chord construction in music. A triad is a three-note chord consisting of a root, a third, and a fifth. By understanding how triads are built and how their inversions work, you'll be able to play chords in different positions, create smooth voice leading, and open up new possibilities in your rhythm and lead playing.

In this lesson, we'll explore the basic structure of triads, the different types of triads, and how to create and use their inversions across the fretboard.

What is a Triad?

A triad is a three-note chord made up of the root, the third, and the fifth. Each note in the triad plays a specific role in defining the chord's sound and character:

- **Root:** The base note of the chord, giving the chord its name (e.g., C in a C major triad).
- **Third:** The note that determines whether the chord is major or minor (e.g., E in a C major triad, E $\flat$ in a C minor triad).
- **Fifth:** The note that adds stability to the chord (e.g., G in a C major triad).

Types of Triads

There are four main types of triads, each with a distinct sound based on the intervals between the root, third, and fifth:

1. **Major Triad:** Root, Major 3rd, Perfect 5th
 - Example: C (Root), E (Major 3rd), G (Perfect 5th).
2. **Minor Triad:** Root, Minor 3rd, Perfect 5th
 - Example: C (Root), E $\flat$ (Minor 3rd), G (Perfect 5th).
3. **Diminished Triad:** Root, Minor 3rd, Diminished 5th
 - Example: C (Root), E $\flat$ (Minor 3rd), G $\flat$ (Diminished 5th).
4. **Augmented Triad:** Root, Major 3rd, Augmented 5th
 - Example: C (Root), E (Major 3rd), G $\sharp$ (Augmented 5th).

Each triad type has its own unique character and can be used to create different harmonic colors.



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Building Triads on the Guitar

On the guitar, triads can be played in several positions and on different string sets. It's essential to learn triad shapes on various string groups (e.g., E-A-D strings, A-D-G strings, etc.) to master their usage.

How to Build Triads on the Fretboard:

1. Choose a Root Note:

- Select a root note to start your triad (e.g., C on the 3rd fret of the A string).

2. Find the Third:

- For a major triad, move up four frets from the root note.
- For a minor triad, move up three frets from the root note.

3. Find the Fifth:

- Move up seven frets from the root for a perfect 5th.
- Move up six frets for a diminished 5th (diminished triad).
- Move up eight frets for an augmented 5th (augmented triad).

Common Triad Shapes on the Guitar:

Root on the Low E String:

- **Major Triad:** Root on the E string, 3rd on the A string, 5th on the D string.
- **Minor Triad:** Root on the E string, minor 3rd on the A string, 5th on the D string.

Root on the A String:

- **Major Triad:** Root on the A string, 3rd on the D string, 5th on the G string.
- **Minor Triad:** Root on the A string, minor 3rd on the D string, 5th on the G string.

What are Triad Inversions?

Inversions are different ways of playing the same triad by rearranging the order of the notes. In an inversion, one of the other notes (the 3rd or 5th) replaces the root as the lowest note of the chord. This creates new voicings and allows for smoother transitions between chords.

Types of Triad Inversions:

1. **Root Position:** The root is the lowest note (e.g., C-E-G).



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2. **1st Inversion:** The 3rd is the lowest note (e.g., E-G-C).
3. **2nd Inversion:** The 5th is the lowest note (e.g., G-C-E).

Each inversion has a distinct sound and can be used to create more variety in your chord progressions.

How to Create Triad Inversions:

1. **1st Inversion:**
 - Move the root note up an octave.
 - Example: C-E-G becomes E-G-C.
2. **2nd Inversion:**
 - Move the 3rd up an octave.
 - Example: E-G-C becomes G-C-E.

Triad Inversion Shapes on the Fretboard:

Inversions can be played in various shapes across the fretboard. Each string set has its own unique shapes for root position, 1st inversion, and 2nd inversion.

Example: C Major Triad Inversions on the E-A-D String Set

1. **Root Position:** C (Root) - E (3rd) - G (5th).
2. **1st Inversion:** E (3rd) - G (5th) - C (Root).
3. **2nd Inversion:** G (5th) - C (Root) - E (3rd).

When to Use Triad Inversions

1. **Create Smooth Voice Leading:**
 - Use inversions to move between chords without large jumps in pitch. This makes your chord transitions sound smoother and more connected.
2. **Add Variety to Chord Progressions:**
 - Play different inversions of the same chord to add variety and texture to a progression.
3. **Enhance Arpeggios and Melodies:**
 - Use triad inversions to create melodic lines and arpeggios that outline the harmony of a chord progression.
4. **Simplify Complex Chords:**



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- Inversions can be used to play simplified versions of complex chords, making it easier to play them in different positions on the neck.
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Exercises for Practicing Triads and Inversions

Exercise 1: Building Triads on the Fretboard

1. Choose a root note (e.g., G) on the low E string.
2. Build a G major triad (G, B, D) in root position, 1st inversion, and 2nd inversion.
3. Repeat for G minor, G diminished, and G augmented.

Exercise 2: Moving Through Inversions

1. Choose a chord (e.g., C major).
2. Play the C major triad in root position, then move to 1st inversion (E-G-C), and finally to 2nd inversion (G-C-E).
3. Practice moving smoothly between each inversion.

Exercise 3: Applying Inversions in a Progression

1. Choose a simple chord progression (e.g., C-G-Am-F).
2. Play each chord using its root position and then its inversions.
3. Experiment with different voicings and find which combinations sound best.